Art-chaeology

ASSIGNMENT 1 / Build a site of layered stories / Postcard-size to 9 x 12 inches

01 START WITH A STORY



Choose a memory, place, or question. Your panel is an Art-chaeology site. Brush on binder and press down your first stratum: one layer of paper.

LOOK FOR
Contrasting colors, torn edges, and fragments of words.

02 ADD RAISED TEXTURES



Arrange string, wrinkled paper, or a small dry leaf. Secure the shapes. Leave string tails beyond the edge if you plan to pull them later.

LOOK FOR
A few low ridges with open areas between them.

Art-chaeology: Build, bury, and excavate a story through layers of art.

GATHER YOUR MATERIALS

Support: Thin plywood, a prepared wood panel, stiff cardboard, or very rigid paper.
Paper: Newspaper, maps, tissue, packaging, flyers, or painted scraps.
Binder: Elmer's-type white glue, Mod Podge, homemade wheat paste, acrylic gel, or acrylic paint for lightweight paper.
Texture + tools: String, yarn, wrinkled paper, optional acrylic caulk, brushes, plastic cards, blunt craft sticks, scissors, paint, water, and rags.

Build the strata

ASSIGNMENT 2 / Deposit paper, fiber, and color / Complete during session 1

03 PRESS PAPER OVER TEXTURE



Brush binder over the base. Lay thin paper or tissue over the raised shapes. Gently press it into the valleys with a brush; avoid flooding the panel.

LOOK FOR
Raised string visible beneath a continuous paper skin.

04 BUILD, HIDE, AND DRY



Build strata (layers) of paper and color. Bury earlier marks like traces of the past. Leave loose corners and string tails. Dry flat before excavation.

LOOK FOR
Stratigraphy: the order of your layers, revealed where colors overlap.

SESSION 1 / ABOUT 60 MINUTES

10 min: Study the visual examples. Notice ridges, torn edges, and hidden information.
10 min: Choose a story and collect papers. **35 min:** Build and bury the surface.
5 min: Label your work, clean up, and set it flat to dry.

Binder tip: Wheat paste and school glue may soften again with moisture. Acrylic gel and Mod Podge become more water-resistant. Use a small test scrap to check how your chosen binder peels. Drying time varies with thickness and humidity.

Excavate the surface

ASSIGNMENT 3 / Uncover traces of earlier strata / Begin after the layers have dried

05 PULL A PATH THROUGH



Test one loose string tail. Pull slowly back across the surface to lift a narrow channel. Stop if the whole layer lifts. Leave other strings buried for relief.

LOOK FOR
A torn path exposing a different color underneath.

06 EXCAVATE, EDIT, AND FINISH



Excavate by peeling loose corners and scraping gently with a blunt stick. Reveal earlier strata. Keep some found fragments as clues to your story.

LOOK FOR
A balance of buried areas, exposed color, and raised texture.

SESSION 2 / REVEAL + REFLECT

5 min: Predict what is hidden. **35 min:** Pull, peel, and gently scrape.
15 min: Adjust the composition. **5 min:** Share one discovery.
Finish with: Visible strata, one excavated pathway, and raised texture. Describe one artifact: a human-made paper or image fragment that carries your story.

Studio care: Use blunt tools; avoid dry sanding and dust. Optional acrylic caulk requires ventilation and teacher supervision. If a layer resists peeling, try another loose edge rather than forcing it.

Bury an image, reveal a story

OPTIONAL EXTENSION / Buried images + deeper strata

01 PLAN WHAT WILL REAPPEAR



Choose photocopies of a house, person, tree, or meaningful place. Glue them down. Lay string across selected areas, leaving long tails beyond the panel. Cover parts with contrasting thin papers.

NOTICE
Make a site record: photograph your base to locate buried images later.

02 LET THE STRING LIFT THE PAPER



Deposit several thin strata above the string, alternating colors. Test a separate small sample first. Once dry, hold the board and pull one tail slowly back across the surface.

NOTICE
The string catches the paper from below; torn edges expose several colors at once.

Test first: Binder, paper thickness, and drying affect the tear. Start with a few thin layers on a scrap before building a thicker surface. A clean channel is not guaranteed.

Read the excavated layers

OPTIONAL EXTENSION / Read the strata, then choose what to keep

03 OPEN A CHANNEL IN SMALL SECTIONS



Pull a short distance, pause, and inspect. Peel loose flaps with your fingers or a blunt craft stick. Stop if the whole collage lifts. Leave some string embedded for raised lines.

NOTICE
Context: where an image fragment lies and what surrounds it helps tell its story.

04 BALANCE IMAGE AND TEXTURE



Reveal enough of your image to suggest a story: a window, face, branch, or roofline. Keep other parts hidden. Add a final scrap or color only where the composition needs it.

NOTICE
Both approaches work: the abstract surface on pages 1-3 and this image-based collage.

Art-chaeology field notes: Which strata came first? What artifacts did you uncover? How did their context change? Record one discovery. Generated examples suggest possibilities, not exact results.